

care's best, overcoming petty politics and the pressure of people



## ALL INDIA INSTITUTE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES, DELHI CRITICAL CARE

A fourth year MBBS student and president of the students' union (formed in 1956) Suwen Kumar walks down the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), knowing that each operation theatre, laboratory and classroom has a history. Of being the first Indian hospital to perform a heart transplant in 1994, the first to execute a combined liver-pancreatic transplant on a diabetic patient and Asia's first to perform a robotic radical prostatectomy in 2006. This is reason enough for it to rank third in a global ranking of medical schools (says a *Newsweek International* survey in 2006). Kumar was one of 5,000 students who were part of a silent protest against reservation in 2006. "This was the first time I faced water canons or went to jail or went on a fast," says Kumar. It seems like this vigour is deeply instilled within the institute, despite protracted political battles, the most recent between former director Dr P. Venugopal and Union Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss. A first batch student and AIIMS director (between October 1996 and November 2003), P.K. Dave, is proof of this. "Rajkumari Amrit Kaur was the first president of AIIMS and the then health minister. The subsequent minister didn't see the need for the institution and had pushed to lock it up," he says. Dave and his colleagues wheeled beds, sat in the OPD filling forms for patients and overstayed shifts without letting their passion fail.

AIIMS attracts two lakh students annually for the MBBS course, of which 80,000 appear for the entrance examination, while only 50 (33 in the general category and 17 in the reserved) are accepted. But when it comes to caring for 10,000 OPD cases daily from across India, the story turns sour. With the population running over a billion and the lopsided ratio of health problems to treatments available, AIIMS isn't earning a good name. Untreated patients lying on stretchers on the roads and overcrowded wards have become defining symbols of this institution. According to head of department, urology, N.P. Gupta, an organised system is much needed to fully serve the purpose AIIMS was intended to.

by Purvi Malhotra

**BRAIN FACTORY:** Post graduate students at the campus